

Imagination to inception

I grew up reading the masters – Arthur C Clarke and Isaac Asimov. There was something to be said about the sheer believability of the content. Even if you were studying the laws of physics in school, these masters of sci-fi were able to convince you that there were shortcuts past Einstein's barriers of Physics. Thus, I happily went zipping across the universe with the protagonists in the novel of the week, with my imagination stoked, but my reasoning mind firmly planted in reality – thinking, "Hey, this really could happen in 3000 AD."

Even today, I re-read a lot of them, so hooked to every page that I have to play hooky from work because I was awake all night. I'm also one of those people who will tell you that good sci-fi books died along with the two masters, but I digress...

Since people hardly read books anymore, creativity and imagination is not something that's inspired by paper anymore – it's all video and images these days. And for most, letting our imaginations run wild is way more exercise than we want. We need to touch, feel or experience in some way...not imagine.

Our regular dosage of oohs and aahs comes from the movies. It's hardly imagination, because you only believe what you see... but it does captivate us nonetheless. Another way we find fantasy is in still images – desktop wallpapers, paintings, comics, etc. However, the latest fad is the "concept". Like everything else before, this concept of "concepts" has been around for ages already. Sometimes also called prototypes, the concept first became famous with the automobile industry.

However, over the years, we seem to tire of the latest fad – we're already fed-up of the iPad and the new tablet craze. We're now busy salivating over the sleek and dreamy concept gadgets that designers are only too happy to throw at us. Also, the days of concept imaging are already behind us; we expect 3D videos these days!

The Mozilla Seabird is one of the concept videos that caught everyone's fancy in late September. For those of you who haven't seen the video, do a YouTube search and watch it – in 3D.

If the comments on the mozillalabs.com site are any indication, an actual phone like this one would sell like hotcakes. I read hundreds of the 1024 comments before it got boring, and all basically said, "Wow! I want one."

Although I'll be the first to admit that the concept video is well done, and it definitely is a cool looking gadget, it's hardly practical.

A projected keyboard may be cool, but if you can use it only on a flat surface, why not a foldable, bendable one? The pico projector also assumes I would have a dock sitting about in a dark room to use my phone as a laptop replacement. However, I think the cloud offers more of a solution there than a one-stop gadget that tries to be everything, and just about achieves it. And where exactly would I project if I were in a taxi, or on one of our over-cramped flights, with my legs almost pressed-up against my chest; and God forbid I wanted to have a meeting outdoors at noon in India!

Of course I have no doubt that if this phone were released tomorrow, hordes would spend their life savings to get it. Being practical is so boring isn't it?

It's not just about concept gadgets. The same applies to the "cool" gadgets of today. If you can afford it (or even if you can't), you want it; doesn't matter if you need it, or if it's practical.

On my way to work one day, I was on Gtalk from my phone chatting with a young reader (you know who you are), who was about to go off to college, and wanted to spend about Rs. 26K on an iPod Touch 64 GB.

"Why?" I asked.

"Because it's portable, has a lot of storage, and is the only device I will own for the next three years."

"A netbook is portable, has a lot more storage and will let you get college work done, and you'll even have money left over to buy a PMP!"

"Hmm...will think about it..."

I wonder if he was able to resist the temptation, and buy smart rather than buy cool. I doubt it, because I see people buying an iPhone, and never using it for apps, music or videos; and others who have bought a BlackBerry, but just to send SMSes...and to be a BlackBerry Boy.

All it takes is a cool 3D video, and people happily throw away practicality in favour of spending big bucks on features they *imagine* would be cool to own. We may have lost the ability to use our imaginations properly, but the manufacturers of fantasy have certainly managed to master the art of inception – it's not as hard as the movie made it out to be, apparently. 



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